

Later Wittgenstein - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LATER WITTGENSTEIN: LANGUAGE AT WORK

Picture and logical form -> use, language-games, rule-following and therapy

TRANSITION

- Early: picture facts
- One logical essence
- Later: describe uses
- Continuity: clarify

PUBLIC PRACTICE

- Meaning as use
- Language-games
- Grammar and training
- Forms of life

NORMATIVITY

- Rule-following
- Diary S failure
- Criteria and avowal
- Therapeutic method

EXAMINER'S CENTRAL DISTINCTION

Public criteria != behaviourism != majority rule; private != secret
Use is a qualified reminder within practices, not a new universal essence of meaning.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

Later Wittgenstein - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session 3

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION 3

RAPID REVISION 1 - The Break from the Tractatus - Placement, the One-Screen Map and Why the Later Philosophy Begins	3
RAPID REVISION 2 - Meaning as Use - the Toolbox, the PI 43 Qualification and Mastery of a Technique	3
RAPID REVISION 3 - Family Resemblance - Overlapping Similarities, Fuzzy Boundaries and 'Don't Think, But Look'	3
RAPID REVISION 4 - Language-Games - Language Woven into Activity, the Builders and Rules by Training	3
RAPID REVISION 5 - Forms of Life - PI 19, Agreement in Form of Life, the Lion Remark and the Bedrock of Justification	4
RAPID REVISION 6 - Rule-Following and the Paradox (PI 201) - Interpretation Regress, Practice and Going On	4
RAPID REVISION 7 - The Private-Language Argument - Logical Privacy, the Diary 'S', the Beetle and Public Criteria	4
RAPID REVISION 8 - Criteria vs Symptoms, PI 580 Outward Criteria and the Behaviourism Charge Answered	4
RAPID REVISION 9 - Philosophy as Therapy - Language on Holiday, the Fly-Bottle, Perspicuous Representation and 'Leaves Everything as It Is'	5
RAPID REVISION 10 - Aspect-Seeing and the Duck-Rabbit - Seeing-As, the Dawning of an Aspect and Aspect-Blindness	5
ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 40 QUESTIONS	13

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE 21

EXAM APPLICATION 1 - The Break from the Tractatus - Placement, the One-Screen Map and Why the Later Philosophy Begins	21
EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Meaning as Use - the Toolbox, the PI 43 Qualification and Mastery of a Technique	21
EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Family Resemblance - Overlapping Similarities, Fuzzy Boundaries and 'Don't Think, But Look'	21
EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Language-Games - Language Woven into Activity, the Builders and Rules by Training	22
EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Forms of Life - PI 19, Agreement in Form of Life, the Lion Remark and the Bedrock of Justification	22
EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Rule-Following and the Paradox (PI 201) - Interpretation Regress, Practice and Going On	22
EXAM APPLICATION 7 - The Private-Language Argument - Logical Privacy, the Diary 'S', the Beetle and Public Criteria	22
EXAM APPLICATION 8 - Criteria vs Symptoms, PI 580 Outward Criteria and the Behaviourism Charge Answered	23
EXAM APPLICATION 9 - Philosophy as Therapy - Language on Holiday, the Fly-Bottle, Perspicuous Representation and 'Leaves Everything as It Is'	23
EXAM APPLICATION 10 - Aspect-Seeing and the Duck-Rabbit - Seeing-As, the Dawning of an Aspect and Aspect-Blindness	23
Workbook Source Audit	24
Practice Design	24
SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 7 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS	24
ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS	28

Later Wittgenstein - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

RAPID REVISION 1 - The Break from the Tractatus - Placement, the One-Screen Map and Why the Later Philosophy Begins

Rapid recall

- Two Wittgensteins: *Tractatus* (1921, picturing) vs *Investigations* (1953, use). Same author, opposed pictures of meaning.
- Four flips: picturing -> **use**; one essence -> **family resemblance**; ideal language -> **ordinary language in order**; private reference -> **private language impossible**. - Reasons for the shift: **colour-exclusion problem (1929)**, the **Augustinian picture** is too narrow, philosophy needs **description not theory**. - Method slogan: "**Don't think, but look.**" Philosophy **describes**, it does not explain. - **Provenance trap**: the *Investigations* is **posthumous, 1953**, edited by Anscombe and Rhees; do not say "Wittgenstein published" it. - Ownership: **7** owned parts 2018-2025; **2021** is the empty year. - **Practice link**: MCQs 1-3; PYQs 2023 Q4(c), 2025 Q3(a).

RAPID REVISION 2 - Meaning as Use - the Toolbox, the PI 43 Qualification and Mastery of a Technique

Rapid recall

- Thesis (PI 43): **the meaning of a word is its use in the language** - "for a large class of cases - **though not for all**" (quote the hedge). - Words are **tools in a toolbox**: ask the job, not the object. "The", "if", "five", "pain" have no object. - **Understanding = mastery of a technique** = being able to *go on* correctly; a public ability, not a private image.
- Meaning is **context-dependent** - fixed by the language-game ("Water!"). - **Trap**: flattening section 43 into "all meaning is use"; treating use-theory as a new *theory* Wittgenstein endorses.
- **Practice link**: MCQs 4-6; PYQs 2023 Q4(c), 2025 Q3(a).

RAPID REVISION 3 - Family Resemblance - Overlapping Similarities, Fuzzy Boundaries and 'Don't Think, But Look'

Rapid recall

- **Games** share no single feature - only "a complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing". Model: a **family** (nose, gait, temperament). - Consequence: **concepts need not have sharp boundaries**; definitions by necessary-and-sufficient conditions are not always possible - and that is fine. - Method: "**Don't think, but look!**" - describe the variety, do not posit an essence. - **Bridge**: because "game" has no essence, "language is a game" does not smuggle one in - it dissolves the search. (2018 link.) - **Trap**: treating "family resemblance" as itself the shared property; demanding sharp edges. - **Practice link**: MCQs 7-9; PYQ 2018 Q1(c).

RAPID REVISION 4 - Language-Games - Language Woven into Activity, the Builders and Rules by Training

Rapid recall

- **Language-game (Sprachspiel)** = language + the activities into which it is woven; **countless** games, each with its own rules/purpose. - **Builders' example**: "Slab!" -> brings a slab; a **complete** primitive language, not a broken bit of ours - meaning needs a *role in a practice*, not logical form.
- **Rules by training** (drill, example, correction), not by grasping a Platonic essence or hidden calculus. - Language is **living**: games are born and die. - **Chain**: many games -> no essence (family resemblance) -> rules by practice -> forms of life. - **Practice link**: MCQs 10-12; PYQs 2018 Q1(c), 2022 Q1(c).

RAPID REVISION 5 - Forms of Life - PI 19, Agreement in Form of Life, the Lion Remark and the Bedrock of Justification

Rapid recall

- **PI 19:** "To imagine a language means to imagine a **form of life**." (Lebensform) - **Agreement in form of life, not in opinion** - shared *doing*, not shared beliefs; blocks both relativist and intellectualist misreadings.
- **Lion remark:** too different a form of life -> no understanding, even with speech. - **Bedrock:** "This is simply what I do" - justification ends in practice; forms of life are "the given". - **2022 anomaly:** the printed word is "**motion**" (retained), read as "notion". - **Trap:** turning forms of life into cultural relativism; the background is largely *natural*.
- **Practice link:** MCQs 13-15; PYQ 2022 Q1(c).

RAPID REVISION 6 - Rule-Following and the Paradox (PI 201) - Interpretation Regress, Practice and Going On

Rapid recall

- **PI 201 paradox:** "no course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with the rule." - **Regress point:** you cannot fix a rule by adding an interpretation - that needs its own rule, forever. - **Resolution:** grasping a rule is "**not an interpretation**" but is **exhibited in obeying**; rule-following is a **practice/custom** grounded in training and form of life. - **Normativity kept:** right/wrong survives, fixed by shared practice, not private seeming. - **Bridge:** public criterion of correctness -> **no private rule -> no private language**.
- **Interpretive flag:** Kripkenstein = sceptical paradox + community solution; a reading, contested by Baker/Hacker - keep labelled. - **Practice link:** MCQs 16-19; feeds PYQs 2019 Q3(b), 2024 Q1(d), 2020 Q4(c).

RAPID REVISION 7 - The Private-Language Argument - Logical Privacy, the Diary 'S', the Beetle and Public Criteria

Rapid recall

- **Private language (exact target):** words for **logically private** sensations, unintelligible to others *in principle* - NOT a code, NOT talking to yourself.
- **Diary 258:** name a private sensation "S"; no independent check of "same" -> "whatever seems right is right" -> "we can't talk about 'right'." No possible mistake -> no meaning. - **Beetle 293:** private object "drops out as irrelevant"; "the box might even be empty." Meaning is carried by criterion-governed use. - **Public criteria:** sensation-words get sense from public circumstances (feeds subtopic 8). - **Solipsism (2019):** the critique of solipsism *culminates in* the critique of private language - the private world cannot even be said.
- **Trap:** it does NOT deny inner life or claim "we can't know other minds." - **Practice link:** MCQs 20-23; PYQs 2019 Q3(b), 2020 Q4(c), 2024 Q1(d).

RAPID REVISION 8 - Criteria vs Symptoms, PI 580 Outward Criteria and the Behaviourism Charge Answered

Rapid recall

- **Criterion = grammatical** (helps fix meaning, *defeasible*); **symptom = inductive** (experience-correlated). Not a difference of degree. - **PI 580:** "An 'inner process' stands in need of **outward criteria**." States grammar; does not deny the inner. - **Defeasibility** is the anti-behaviourism hinge: wincing without pain (acting) is possible -> pain != pain-behaviour -> **not behaviourism**. - **Behaviourism reply (PI 304, 307-308):** Wittgenstein rejects the inner *object* as semantic foundation ("grammatical fiction"), **not** the inner life - "not a something, but not a nothing either." - **First-person avowal:** "It hurts" is an *expression*, not a criterion-based report; criteria govern the third-person case (asymmetry).
- **Trap:** "criteria are reliable symptoms" (collapses grammar into induction). - **Practice link:** MCQs 24-27; feeds PYQs 2020 Q4(c), 2019 Q3(b).

RAPID REVISION 9 - Philosophy as Therapy - Language on Holiday, the Fly-Bottle, Perspicuous Representation and 'Leaves Everything as It Is'

Rapid recall

- **Diagnosis:** "philosophical problems arise when **language goes on holiday**"; "philosophy is a battle against the **bewitchment** of our intelligence by means of language" (PI 109). - **Positive tool:** **perspicuous / surveyable representation** (PI 122, *übersichtliche Darstellung*) - arrange the familiar so we "see connexions".
- **Aim:** "to show the fly the way out of the **fly-bottle**" (PI 309) - problems are **dissolved**, not solved. - **Self-limit (quietism):** "philosophy **leaves everything as it is**" (PI 124); no theses (PI 128); "puts everything before us" (PI 126). - **Plurality:** "not a philosophical method, though there are... **different therapies**" (PI 133). - **Objection/reply:** "no theses" looks self-refuting -> reply: reminders, not metaphysics; success = intellectual peace. - **Practice link:** MCQs 28-30; closing segment for PYQs 2023 Q4(c), 2025 Q3(a).

RAPID REVISION 10 - Aspect-Seeing and the Duck-Rabbit - Seeing-As, the Dawning of an Aspect and Aspect-Blindness

Rapid recall

- **Duck-rabbit** (Jastrow; PI Part II xi / **PPF**): same marks, different **aspect**. The drawing does not change; the *seeing* does.
- **Seeing-as / seeing an aspect;** the flip = **dawning of an aspect**; the limit case = **aspect-blindness**. - **"Not part of perception... like seeing, and again not like seeing"** - it is **not an interpretation/inference**; the aspect is *experienced*.
- **Payload:** perception is **technique-laden** - the mastery behind meaning-as-use reaches into how we see; anti-empiricist about "bare data + interpretation". - **Meaning-blindness** parallel: experiencing a word with a particular meaning. - **Provenance:** cite **PPF / Part II xi**, credit **Jastrow**; not a numbered Part I remark. - **Practice link:** MCQs 31-32; enrichment for PYQ 2025 Q3(a).

CANONICAL EXAM APPARATUS (PRESERVED VERBATIM)

The examiner apparatus below is reproduced verbatim from the canonical Later-Wittgenstein.md (headings demoted, navigation links stripped). It is preserved intact so that no canonical depth - inter-thinker and inter-school debates, the directive decoder, the graded verdict bank, translation / numbering / provenance discipline, criticisms and replies, common traps, the keyword and statement bank, the restored 2018/2020 dossier, the corpus depth delta, PYQ routing, answer architecture, link-outs and sources - is lost in the layered reorganisation.

Inter-Thinker / Inter-School Debates

Axis	Later Wittgenstein	Early Wittgenstein	Logical Positivism	Descartes / Empiricism
Meaning	Use in a form of life	Picturing facts (logical form)	Verification	Idea / private reference
Essence of language	None (family resemblance)	One logical form for all propositions	One criterion (verifiability)	Naming inner/outer objects
Metaphysics	Dissolve as language-on-holiday (therapy)	Show what cannot be said; be silent	Reject as meaningless	Pursue as first philosophy
Private inner realm	Logically impossible as foundation of meaning	Not explicitly addressed (but logical form is objective)	Not central	Foundational (cogito, sense-data)
Philosophy's task	Therapy - dissolve confusions; "leaves everything as it is"	Draw limits of the sayable	Analysis; eliminate pseudo-problems	Build system from foundations
Ethics	Embedded in forms of life; no philosophical theory needed	Beyond the sayable (the mystical)	Emotive / non-cognitive	Rational theory possible

Directive Decoder - What Each Command Word Obliges You To Do

Directive	What it demands	Structural obligation for this file	Fatal error
Discuss meaning as use	show the contrast it replaces , then the positive account	Augustinian/referential picture (§1) -> use -> family resemblance -> forms of life. Give a worked example (the builders' "Slab!").	"Wittgenstein said meaning is use" plus a paraphrase.
Critically examine the private-language argument (2024, 2019)	reconstruct the five-step logical core , then the criteria/symptoms defence	§5.4 core, then the behaviourism charge with §§304-308 as the reply, then Kripke vs Hacker, then rule.	Retelling the beetle and the diary with no argument-structure.
Elucidate a numbered remark (quotation-led parts)	give the §, then the doctrine, then the work it does	E.g. §580 "an inner process stands in need of outward criteria": say what it does not claim (§5.8 table).	Paraphrasing the sentence.
How does Wittgenstein refute solipsism? (2019 Q3b)	show it is a corollary , not a separate argument	Private language impossible -> the solipsist's own language is public -> the thesis is self-undermining. Add <i>Tractatus</i> 5.62 for the early/late contrast.	Treating it as an independent refutation.
Compare early and later Wittgenstein (2025 Q3a, 2023 Q4c)	name the specific doctrines abandoned and what caused each abandonment	Determinacy of sense, simple objects, one logical form, independence of elementary propositions (broken by colour exclusion), sense as picturing.	"He changed his mind about language."
Explain philosophy as therapy	show that the method follows from the diagnosis	§38 holiday -> §115 picture -> §123 disorientation -> §309 fly-bottle -> §124/§128/§133 consequences.	Quoting the fly-bottle with no account of why the bottle is open.
Assess "family resemblance"	show what it denies (essences) and what it permits (extensible concepts)	Games as the worked case; then the objection that unlimited resemblance makes any two things similar, and the reply that the concept is bounded by practice, not by definition.	Listing games.
Comment / Do you agree?	a defended ruling in line 1	Take a side on behaviourism, on Kripke's reading, or on quietism - and defend it.	Reporting the debate.

Graded Verdict Bank - Executable Closing Positions

Sub-topic	10-mark verdict	15-mark verdict	20-mark verdict
The break from the <i>Tractatus</i> *	The later work is not a change of subject but the dismantling of two <i>Tractatus</i> presuppositions Wittgenstein was himself the first to identify.	...Colour exclusion destroyed the independence of elementary propositions; the demand for determinate sense was seen to be a requirement imposed by a <i>picture</i> , not discovered in language.	The continuity is the conception of philosophy: in 1921 it is an activity of elucidation ending in silence, in 1953 an activity of therapy ending in the ability to stop. What changes is the diagnosis of what misleads us - logical form in the early work, the surface grammar of ordinary language in the later. Read this way the two books are one project pursued with opposite assumptions about where sense comes from.

Sub-topic	10-mark verdict	15-mark verdict	20-mark verdict
Meaning and use	Meaning is not a relation between word and object but a place in a practice ; asking for the meaning is asking for the technique of employment.	...This is not verificationism: use is not exhausted by checking-conditions, and imperatives, jokes, greetings and prayers all have use without truth-conditions. The verification principle is a special case of the use-theory, illegitimately generalised.	The doctrine's strength is that it explains the phenomena the referential theory cannot - logical constants, sensation words, proper names of the non-existent. Its cost is normativity: if use fixes meaning, what distinguishes a mistake from a change? Wittgenstein's answer - that grammar and training set the standard - is adequate for stable practices and strained for creative and evolving ones, and this is the live tension in the doctrine.
Language-games / forms of life	Language is not one thing with one essence but an indefinite family of practices woven into activities.	..."Forms of life" is where explanation stops - " this is simply what I do " (§217) - which is a limit, not an evasion, since any justification must terminate somewhere.	The concept of a form of life is the doctrine's greatest strength and its greatest obscurity: it grounds meaning in something more than convention (it is natural history, not agreement) while leaving unsettled whether forms of life are biological, cultural or both. The dispute between the "naturalist" and "culturalist" readings is unresolved, and any answer that names it is operating above the ordinary level.
Rule-following	The paradox is that no interpretation can fix a rule, since every interpretation itself needs interpreting; the regress ends in a practice , not in a further rule.	...§201's own resolution is that "there is a way of grasping a rule which is not an interpretation, but which is exhibited in what we call obeying the rule" - so the sceptical paradox is a <i>symptom</i> of the interpretation-model, not a conclusion.	Kripke's "sceptical solution" reads the argument as conceding that no fact constitutes meaning and replacing truth-conditions with community assertibility-conditions; Baker-Hacker and McDowell reply that Wittgenstein dissolves rather than concedes the paradox. The examiner-safe ruling: Kripke's reading is philosophically fertile and exegetically weak - §201 explicitly names the paradox a <i>misunderstanding</i> , which is not how a sceptic writes.
Private language	A sign with no possible independent standard of correct application is not a sign; the private diarist only seems to mean something.	...The argument does not deny private <i>experience</i> , only private <i>meaning</i> ; and it works by removing the correct/seems-correct distinction, not by demanding public verification.	Its target is the whole Cartesian-empiricist architecture: if sensation-words cannot be privately grounded, then neither the cogito's inner theatre nor the sense-datum base can be the foundation of knowledge. Its cost is that it purchases this result with a strong premise - that a criterion of correctness must be <i>possible</i> for anyone - which Ayer's Crusoe case tests and which no formulation has made uncontroversially compelling.
Criteria vs symptoms	Criteria are grammatical and defeasible; symptoms are inductive. That single distinction blocks the behaviourist reading.	...It allows Wittgenstein to say that behaviour is constitutive of the <i>concept</i> of pain without being identical to pain, and to preserve the first/third-person asymmetry the behaviourist must deny.	The distinction is what makes the philosophy of mind here genuinely third-way: anti-Cartesian without reduction. Its instability is that Wittgenstein himself notes the grammar <i>fluctuates</i> between criterion and symptom (§354), so the distinction cannot be drawn once and for all - which is either a candid recognition of how concepts work or an admission that the key notion is not sharp. Say which you think, and why.

Sub-topic	10-mark verdict	15-mark verdict	20-mark verdict
Therapy / fly-bottle	Philosophical problems are disorientation, not ignorance; the fly-bottle is open, and the remedy is a change of method, not a new theory.	...This is why "philosophy leaves everything as it is" and why no theses are advanced; success is measured by the ability to stop.	The quietist charge is the one to engage. It cannot be dismissed, because Wittgenstein does deliberately and severely narrow what philosophy may do. The defence worth making is that the narrowing is <i>local</i> : it forbids explanatory theory in the philosophy of language and mind, where the confusions are grammatical, and says nothing about ethics or politics. Whether that restriction can be principled, rather than merely announced, is the standing question.
Aspect-seeing	"I see that it has not changed; and yet I see it differently" - seeing-as is neither bare perception nor inference, and it presupposes mastery of a technique.	...It therefore completes the case against the Given: what one can see depends on what one can do with concepts.	Aspect-seeing is also a description of Wittgenstein's own method. Therapy adds no facts and changes no object; it makes a new aspect of the familiar language-game dawn. That the doctrine of aspects and the conception of philosophy are the same thought is the strongest evidence that the later work is a unified philosophy and not, as Russell alleged, a collection of aphorisms.

Translation, Numbering and Provenance Discipline

Wittgenstein wrote in German; the *Investigations* is a posthumous compilation. Both facts constrain what you may assert.

Item	Status	Practice
<i>Philosophische Untersuchungen / Philosophical Investigations</i>	Written 1929-49; published posthumously in 1953 , edited by Anscombe and Rhees ; German-English facing pages	ANALYSIS: Never write "Wittgenstein published the <i>Investigations</i> ." He did not publish it, and the arrangement of remarks is partly editorial.
Translations	Anscombe (1953); revised by Hacker and Schulte (4th edn, 2009)	ANALYSIS: The 4th edition changes wording in places and - crucially - renames Part II as "Philosophy of Psychology - A Fragment," renumbering its sections . So "PI Part II §xi" (older editions) = "PPF §§111ff" (4th edn). If you cite the duck-rabbit, say "Part II §xi / PPF" rather than a bare number.
Citation by § number FACT:	Part I remarks are numbered §1-§693 and the numbering is identical across editions and translations	Use § numbers rather than page numbers: §1 (Augustine), §7/§23 (language-games), §38 (language on holiday), §43 (meaning is use), §66-67 (family resemblance), §109 (description not explanation), §115 (a picture held us captive), §123, §124, §128, §133, §201 (the paradox), §217 (spade turned), §241-242 (agreement in form of life), §243-271 (private language), §244 (avowal), §255, §258 (diary), §293 (beetle), §304, §307-308 (behaviourism), §309 (fly-bottle), §354 (criteria/symptoms), §580 (outward criteria).

Item	Status	Practice
"Meaning is use"	ANALYSIS: §43 is carefully hedged: " For a large class of cases - though not for all - in which we employ the word 'meaning' it can be defined thus: the meaning of a word is its use in the language."	WRONG: Never quote it without the qualification. Dropping "for a large class of cases" is the most frequent misquotation in the whole syllabus, and it converts a careful remark into the slogan Wittgenstein was avoiding.
"Language goes on holiday" (§38)	ANALYSIS: The German is <i>wenn die Sprache feiert</i> - closer to "when language is idling " or "on vacation from work." Anscombe's "holiday" is idiomatic but slightly misleading; the image is machinery running without load, not a vacation.	Give the § and gloss the image, or paraphrase.
Fly-bottle (§309)	FACT: "To show the fly the way out of the fly-bottle" is stable across editions	FACT: Safe verbatim with §309.
Beetle in a box (§293)	FACT:	FACT: Safe with §293.
Diary "S" (§258)	ANALYSIS: Renderings of "whatever is going to seem right to me is right" vary slightly	Give §258; paraphrase rather than quote if unsure.
Blue and Brown Books*	Dictated 1933-35 , published 1958	FACT: The source for the criterion/symptom distinction and the angina example. ANALYSIS: They are <i>dictations to students</i> , not a work Wittgenstein prepared for print - say "in the <i>Blue Book</i> " rather than "Wittgenstein wrote."
On Certainty*	Notes from 1949-51 , published 1969	FACT: The source of the "hinge propositions" response to Moore. ANALYSIS: Note it is Wittgenstein's last work and is unrevised.
Kripke's reading	<i>Wittgenstein on Rules and Private Language</i> , 1982	ANALYSIS: Kripke himself presents it as " Wittgenstein's argument as it struck Kripke ," not as exegesis. Say "Kripke's Wittgenstein" (the standard scholarly phrase, "Kripkenstein") and you signal awareness of the distinction.
"Forms of life" (<i>Lebensformen</i>)	Occurs only a handful of times in the <i>Investigations</i> (§19, §23, §241 and PPF)	ANALYSIS: Do not build a large doctrine on it and present that doctrine as Wittgenstein's stated theory; mark the interpretation as interpretation.
Duck-rabbit	The figure is Jastrow's (1899), reproduced by Wittgenstein	ANALYSIS: Do not attribute the drawing to Wittgenstein.

WRONG: **Never write:** that Wittgenstein "denied the existence of inner mental states" (§304 explicitly refuses this); that the private-language argument is directed at codes or at talking to oneself; or that "meaning is use" is offered as a general definition (§43 says otherwise).

Criticisms and Replies

Critic	Objection	Assessment
Ayer / Private-language defenders	A solitary person (Robinson Crusoe) <i>could</i> invent words for sensations - checking memory against itself is no worse than relying on the community.	ANALYSIS: Wittgenstein's defenders reply: even Crusoe uses <i>public-type</i> criteria (regular behaviour, physical correlates); the argument targets <i>logical</i> privacy (no possible check), not physical solitude.
Kripke ("Wittgenstein on Rules and Private Language")	Interprets the rule-following argument as yielding a <i>sceptical paradox</i> - no fact about me determines what I mean; the "solution" is merely communal agreement (a <i>sceptical solution</i>).	CAUTION: Contested reading. Many scholars (Baker & Hacker, McDowell) deny Wittgenstein endorses scepticism about meaning; he dissolves the problem, not concedes it.
Functionalists / Cognitive scientists	Wittgenstein's focus on <i>public</i> criteria ignores the genuine causal role of inner states (brain states).	ANALYSIS: Wittgenstein does not <i>deny</i> inner states exist; he denies they can <i>ground</i> meaning independently of public criteria. Brain states and inner experiences are real but parasitic on public language for their <i>articulation</i> .
Is "meaning = use" too vague?	If meaning is use, how do we distinguish correct use from widespread misuse? Is there no norm beyond consensus?	ANALYSIS: Wittgenstein: grammar provides the norms; training into forms of life sets the standard. But this leaves open whether dead metaphors, poetic extensions, etc. are "uses" or "misuses" - a genuine tension.
Conservatism charge	"Philosophy leaves everything as it is" - does this preclude philosophical progress or critique of social practices?	ANALYSIS: Wittgenstein's point is about <i>conceptual</i> description, not social conservatism. Therapy removes confusion; it does not forbid reform - but the scope of what philosophy <i>can</i> do is deliberately narrowed.

Common UPSC Traps

Trap	Discrimination
"Private language = a secret code"	No. A secret code is still a public language (decipherable). Private language means words whose meaning is constituted by <i>logically</i> private experience - <i>in principle</i> unteachable.
"Wittgenstein denies inner experience exists"	No. He denies inner experience can <i>ground meaning</i> . Pain is real; but "pain" gets its meaning from public use, not from private ostension of a sensation.
"Meaning = use" is a <i>theory</i> of meaning	No. Wittgenstein refuses theories. It is a therapeutic reminder to look at <i>how words are used</i> rather than seeking a hidden essence.
"Family resemblance proves definitions are impossible"	Not quite. It shows that <i>not all</i> concepts admit of necessary-and-sufficient-condition definitions. Some do ("triangle"); many important ones (game, language, number) do not.
"Later Wittgenstein = logical positivism"	No. He <i>rejects</i> verificationism; meaning is use, not verification-conditions. Metaphysics is "language on holiday," not "meaningless."
"The private-language argument refutes solipsism as false"	It does not prove it <i>false</i> (that would require a public-language argument for other minds). It shows solipsism is <i>inexpressible</i> / self-undermining - it cannot coherently be stated.

Trap	Discrimination
"Forms of life" = cultural relativism	CAUTION: Contested. Wittgenstein's "forms of life" may be human-natural (shared biology, natural reactions) rather than culturally specific. He is not a cultural relativist in a straightforward sense.

Keyword and Statement Bank, Restored 2018/2020 Dossier and Corpus Delta

#	Item	Use
1	FACT: <i>"The meaning of a word is its use in the language."</i> (§43)	Core thesis
2	FACT: <i>"To imagine a language means to imagine a form of life."</i> (§19)	Forms of life
3	FACT: <i>"Philosophy is a battle against the bewitchment of our intelligence by means of language."</i> (§109)	Therapeutic conception
4	FACT: <i>"Philosophy leaves everything as it is."</i> (§124)	Non-revisionary therapy
5	FACT: <i>"If a lion could talk, we could not understand him."</i>	Forms of life / incommensurability
6	FACT: <i>"Whatever seems right to me is right - and that only means that here we cannot talk about 'right'."</i> (§258 substance)	Private-language argument
7	FACT: <i>"Don't think, but look!"</i> (§66)	Family resemblance / method
8	ANALYSIS: <i>Language-game (Sprachspiel)</i>	Language + the activity it is woven into
9	ANALYSIS: <i>Beetle-in-a-box</i>	The private object "drops out as irrelevant"
10	ANALYSIS: The rule-following paradox (§201): "no course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with the rule"	Sets up private-language argument

RESTORED 2018/2020 DOCTRINE DOSSIER

Family resemblance and the grammar of games

- FACT: Uses of "game" overlap through criss-crossing similarities without one essence common to all instances. This supports language-games because speaking is a plurality of rule-governed practices, not one representational calculus.
- ANALYSIS: Open texture is not lawlessness: local criteria and practices still distinguish correct from incorrect moves.

The private-diary case

- FACT: A sign intended to name a recurring private sensation needs a criterion for using it correctly on later occasions. Private ostensive definition cannot supply one because whatever seems right would count as right.
- FACT: **Presupposition:** following a rule requires a normatively stable practice, not necessarily a large public audience but criteria not exhausted by present impression. - CAUTION: **Objection -> reply:** first-person sensation reports appear privately authoritative. Wittgenstein does not deny sensations; he argues that the language used to report them derives its grammar from shared practices.

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (complete 2018-2025 audit)

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** Primary ownership is 7 of 112 parts; 2021 remains the only year without an owned part. - FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** The restored years add family resemblance as the grammar of "game" and the private-diary formulation of the private-language problem. - WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not say family resemblance means absence of all order, or that privacy is impossible; the target is a putative rule whose correctness cannot be distinguished from seeming correct.

PYQ Routing (2018-2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 7 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q1(c)	10 marks	How does the notion of 'family resemblance' help Wittgenstein to uphold that 'Language is a game'? Discuss.
2019	Q3(b)	15 marks	Show how Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism culminates in the critique of private language.
2020	Q4(c)	15 marks	"But could we also imagine a language in which a person could write down or give vocal expression to his inner experiences-his feelings, moods and the rest-for his private use?" Critically discuss the answer offered by Wittgenstein to this question.
2022	Q1(c)	10 marks	Establish the tenability of later Wittgenstein's notion of language as form of life. CAUTION: The official English line itself prints " motion "; it is retained rather than silently changed to "notion".
2023	Q4(c)	15 marks	What were the main reasons that led Wittgenstein to shift from picture-theory of meaning to use-theory of meaning? Critically discuss.
2024	Q1(d)	10 marks	Why does later Wittgenstein think that there cannot be a language that only one person can speak - a language that is essentially private? Discuss.
2025	Q3(a)	20 marks	"We should look not to an ideal language which derives its meaning from facts and has a precise 'logical structure but empirically, to the ways in which languages are actually used.'" Explain the transition from early views of Wittgenstein to his later views on language and meaning with reference to this statement. CAUTION: The unmatched opening quotation before logical structure is visible in the official English line and is retained.

See the Western Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

Answer Architecture (10 / 15 / 20 Marks)

10-mark: "Why does later Wittgenstein think there cannot be an essentially private language?" (2024)

Define : Private language = words getting meaning from logically private sensations, in principle unteachable. (NOT a secret code.)
 Argument: (i) Meaningful sign needs a rule with a criterion of correct application.
 (ii) Private "rule" has NO independent criterion - whatever seems right IS right.
 (iii) Therefore no rule, no meaning -> private language is impossible.
 Illustr : Beetle-in-a-box: the private object "drops out as irrelevant."
 Result : Meaning is necessarily public; grounded in shared practice (form of life).

15-mark: "Show how critique of solipsism culminates in critique of private language." (2019)

Frame : Solipsism = "only my experiences are real." To state this, solipsist needs a language referring to HIS private experiences (private language).
 Step 1 : Wittgenstein shows private language is impossible - the "S" diary argument: no independent criterion -> no rule -> no meaning.
 Step 2 : Beetle-in-a-box: private object irrelevant to public meaning.
 Step 3 : If private language is impossible, solipsism cannot be coherently STATED - the language needed to express it presupposes the public world it denies.
 Assess : The critique of solipsism is not a refutation (proving others exist) but a *dissolution* - showing solipsism is self-undermining. The private-language argument provides the decisive ground: language = public practice.
 Close : Solipsism -> private language -> impossible -> solipsism inexpressible. QED.

20-mark: "Explain the transition from early to later views on language and meaning." (2025)

Frame : The same philosopher - from the *Tractatus* (1921) to the *Investigations* (1953).
The single most dramatic self-reversal in 20th-century philosophy.

Body-A : Early: picture theory - proposition = logical picture of a possible fact;
shared logical form; one essence of language; ideal language behind ordinary;
limits of language = limits of the world; silence on the unsayable.

Body-B : Reasons for break - colour-exclusion problem; failure to specify "objects";
realisation that language serves indefinitely many purposes beyond stating facts;
"Augustinian" picture of language covers only a tiny fragment.

Body-C : Later: meaning = USE; language-games (builders, ordering, praying, joking);
family resemblance replaces single essence; forms of life as bedrock;
rule-following grounded in practice, not interpretation.
Consequence: philosophy = therapy (dissolve, don't construct);
private language impossible (criterion-of-correctness argument).

Assess : The transition is from a *theoretical* to a *therapeutic* conception of philosophy.
Early: one theory to rule all meaning. Later: no theory; only description of diverse
practices. Strengths of the later view: liberates philosophy from the tyranny of
the ideal-language model; accounts for richness of actual use. Critique: "use" may
be too broad - when is use *correct*? Risk of quietism ("leaves everything as it is").

Close : The later Wittgenstein does not refute the early - he outgrows him, showing that
the "crystalline purity" of logic was itself a dogma, not a discovery.

Link-Outs and Sources

- Moore-Russell-EarlyWittgenstein - the *Tractatus* that is repudiated; picture theory, saying/showing. - Logical Positivism - verificationism, which "meaning = use" supersedes. The positivists initially claimed the *Tractatus* as their manifesto; the later Wittgenstein disowns them.
- Quine-Strawson - Quine's holism as a parallel dissolution of the analytic/synthetic basis of positivism; Strawson's descriptive metaphysics as conceptual analysis in a different key.
- Critiques of Metaphysics - Wittgenstein's therapeutic dissolution as the fourth assault on metaphysics (after Hume, Kant, Positivism).
- Self and Liberation - the private-language argument bears on the Buddhist *anātman* (no-self) thesis and the Western self/consciousness debate.
- Cross-paper: Religious Language - religion as a language-game / form of life (D.Z. Phillips, Wittgensteinian fideism); 2023 P-II Q5(d).
- PYQ bank: Western Philosophy PYQs, 2018-2025

SOURCES

- Ludwig Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations* (1953) - the primary text (§§1-693). - Ludwig Wittgenstein, *The Blue and Brown Books* (1958) - transitional; early formulations of language-games and private-language ideas. - Saul Kripke, *Wittgenstein on Rules and Private Language* (1982) - influential (and contested) sceptical interpretation. - P.M.S. Hacker, *Wittgenstein: Meaning and Mind* (1990) - the orthodox (non-sceptical) reading. - Y. Masih, *A Critical History of Western Philosophy* (Wittgenstein chapter). - Anthony Kenny, *Wittgenstein* (Penguin, 1973) and *A New History of Western Philosophy*, vol. 4. - Nigel Warburton, *Philosophy: The Classics* (chapter on *Investigations*).

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 40 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-32 are core coverage across all ten subtopics; Questions 33-40 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 10 times.

MCQ 1

The central change from the *Tractatus* to the *Philosophical Investigations* is best described as a move from:

- A. meaning as the picturing of facts to meaning as use in a language
B. meaning as use to meaning as private mental imagery
C. ordinary language to an ideal logical language
D. ethics to philosophy of mathematics

Correct answer: A - meaning as the picturing of facts to meaning as use in a language

Explanation: The later philosophy replaces the picture-theory (a sentence pictures a possible fact) with meaning as use in a form of life. The other options invert or misstate the direction of the shift.

MCQ 2

Which internal problem, noticed by Wittgenstein around 1929, exposed a structural crack in the Tractatus?

A. the paradox of the liar B. the colour-exclusion problem - that 'a is red all over' excludes 'a is green all over', contradicting the independence of elementary propositions C. Russell's theory of descriptions D. the private-language argument

Correct answer: B - the colour-exclusion problem - that 'a is red all over' excludes 'a is green all over', contradicting the independence of elementary propositions

Explanation: The Tractatus required elementary propositions to be logically independent, but colour incompatibility shows two such propositions can exclude each other. The private-language argument is a later, separate result.

MCQ 3

The 'Augustinian picture of language' that Wittgenstein criticises is the idea that:

A. language is a calculus of truth-functions B. philosophy should describe rather than explain C. every word functions by naming an object, and sentences are combinations of such names D. meaning is determined by community consensus

Correct answer: C - every word functions by naming an object, and sentences are combinations of such names

Explanation: Wittgenstein opens the Investigations with Augustine to typify the naming-picture: words are names of objects. It works for 'table' but collapses for 'the', 'if', 'five', 'pain'.

MCQ 4

Which formulation states Wittgenstein's use-thesis with the qualification he actually gives in PI 43?

A. the meaning of a word is always identical with its use B. every word is a name whose meaning is its bearer C. meaning is a private mental act of interpretation D. 'for a large class of cases - though not for all - ... the meaning of a word is its use in the language'

Correct answer: D - 'for a large class of cases - though not for all - ... the meaning of a word is its use in the language'

Explanation: PI 43 is explicitly hedged: 'for a large class of cases - though not for all'. Flattening it into 'meaning is always use' misreports the text; the naming/interpretation options are the views he rejects.

MCQ 5

For the later Wittgenstein, to understand a word is primarily to:

A. have mastered the technique of using it - to be able to 'go on' correctly B. possess a private mental image that accompanies it C. know the object it names D. be able to give a real definition in necessary and sufficient conditions

Correct answer: A - have mastered the technique of using it - to be able to 'go on' correctly

Explanation: Understanding is a public, demonstrable ability (mastery of a technique), not a private inner episode, a naming relation, or the possession of an essence-definition.

MCQ 6

The 'toolbox' analogy is meant to show that:

A. all words ultimately perform the single function of naming B. words have diverse functions, as tools do, so we should ask a word's job rather than its object C. language is a precise calculus like a set of measuring instruments D. only nouns are genuinely meaningful

Correct answer: B - words have diverse functions, as tools do, so we should ask a word's job rather than its object

Explanation: Just as a hammer, glue and ruler do different jobs, words perform diverse functions; asking 'what object does it name?' misfits most of them.

MCQ 7

According to the family-resemblance idea, the various activities we call 'games' are united by:

A. a single defining property present in every game B. an agreed stipulative definition C. a network of overlapping and criss-crossing similarities, with no one feature common to all D. their shared aim of amusement

Correct answer: C - a network of overlapping and criss-crossing similarities, with no one feature common to all

Explanation: Wittgenstein finds 'a complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing', not a common essence; some games lack winners, some skill, some amusement.

MCQ 8

The injunction 'Don't think, but look!' expresses Wittgenstein's demand that we:

A. deduce the hidden essence behind a concept B. trust introspection over observation C. replace ordinary language with a logical notation D. describe the actual variety of uses instead of positing a common essence

Correct answer: D - describe the actual variety of uses instead of positing a common essence

Explanation: It is a methodological slogan for description over theory: inspect how the word is actually used rather than assume a concealed defining feature.

MCQ 9

On Wittgenstein's view, a concept with blurred or fuzzy boundaries is:

A. still perfectly usable - sharp boundaries are not required for a concept to function B. meaningless until sharpened by analysis C. a sign of a defective natural language D. acceptable only in poetry, not in philosophy

Correct answer: A - still perfectly usable - sharp boundaries are not required for a concept to function

Explanation: Blurred edges are a feature, not a defect: 'is a photograph a picture?' need not have a forced answer for 'picture' to work. Demanding sharpness everywhere is the error.

MCQ 10

A 'language-game' (Sprachspiel) in Wittgenstein's technical sense is:

A. a competitive contest played with words B. language together with the activities into which it is woven C. a purely formal calculus of signs D. a children's game that teaches grammar

Correct answer: B - language together with the activities into which it is woven

Explanation: The term denotes 'the whole, consisting of language and the actions into which it is woven'. It is not a contest, a formalism, or a pedagogic device.

MCQ 11

The builders' example ('Slab!', 'Block!') is meant to illustrate that:

A. all languages must share one logical form B. primitive words are meaningless without full grammar C. a small set of words used in a shared practice can be a complete language, not a defective fragment of ours D. ostensive definition alone fixes meaning

Correct answer: C - a small set of words used in a shared practice can be a complete language, not a defective fragment of ours

Explanation: The 'Slab!' language is complete for its purpose, showing meaning needs a role in a practice, not a universal logical form or a full natural grammar.

MCQ 12

For Wittgenstein, we come to follow the rules of a language-game chiefly through:

A. intuiting a Platonic form B. an explicit contract among speakers C. grasping a hidden calculus by introspection D. training - drill, examples and correction within a practice

Correct answer: D - training - drill, examples and correction within a practice

Explanation: Rules are learned by being trained into a practice, not by grasping an essence, signing a convention, or introspecting a calculus.

MCQ 13

PI 19's remark 'to imagine a language means to imagine a form of life' asserts that:

A. a language is inseparable from a mode of living and acting B. languages can be designed independently of any human practice C. imagination is the source of linguistic meaning D. forms of life are private mental states

Correct answer: A - a language is inseparable from a mode of living and acting

Explanation: Language and a form of life are inseparable; the remark is the textual basis of the 2022 question. The other options detach language from practice or privatise it.

MCQ 14

When Wittgenstein says humans 'agree in the language they use', he means agreement:

A. in explicitly stated opinions and theories B. in form of life - shared ways of acting - not in opinions C. reached by majority vote D. guaranteed by a shared logical structure

Correct answer: B - in form of life - shared ways of acting - not in opinions

Explanation: 'Not agreement in opinions but in form of life.' It is shared doing, which blocks both the intellectualist (shared beliefs) and the merely conventional (vote) readings.

MCQ 15

'If a lion could talk, we could not understand him' is used to make the point that:

A. animals lack vocal cords for speech B. translation between human languages is impossible C. understanding presupposes a shared form of life, not merely shared vocabulary D. solitary rule-following is possible

Correct answer: C - understanding presupposes a shared form of life, not merely shared vocabulary

Explanation: A form of life too unlike ours would leave the words without shared purchase; understanding needs a shared background of activity and reaction, not just words.

MCQ 16

The rule-following 'paradox' of PI 201 is that:

A. rules are always vague B. no one ever really follows a rule C. rules must be written to be valid D. 'no course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with the rule'

Correct answer: D - 'no course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with the rule'

Explanation: PI 201 states the paradox verbatim: any continuation can be squared with the rule under some interpretation, so interpretation alone determines nothing.

MCQ 17

Wittgenstein's resolution of the paradox is that grasping a rule is:

A. a practice or custom, exhibited in obeying the rule and going against it in actual cases B. a private act of interpretation C. a matter of consulting a further rule D. an infallible intuition of meaning

Correct answer: A - a practice or custom, exhibited in obeying the rule and going against it in actual cases

Explanation: 'There is a way of grasping a rule which is not an interpretation, but which is exhibited in what we call obeying the rule.' Rule-following is a trained practice.

MCQ 18

Why does adding another rule to 'interpret' the first fail to solve the paradox?

A. because rules cannot be written down B. because it launches an infinite regress - the new rule itself needs interpreting C. because interpretations are always correct D. because only experts may interpret rules

Correct answer: B - because it launches an infinite regress - the new rule itself needs interpreting

Explanation: Each interpreting rule needs its own interpretation, and so on without end; the regress is why Wittgenstein locates correctness in practice, not interpretation.

MCQ 19

On the rule-following considerations, a rule that only one person could in principle check would:

A. be the clearest kind of rule B. be validated by private conviction C. lack any genuine distinction between following it and merely seeming to - so it is no rule D. be correct whenever it feels correct

Correct answer: C - lack any genuine distinction between following it and merely seeming to - so it is no rule

Explanation: Without a criterion independent of one's impression, 'right' collapses into 'seems right'. This is the bridge from rule-following to the private-language argument.

MCQ 20

In Wittgenstein's argument, an 'essentially private language' means a language whose words:

A. are a secret code known only to a spy B. are spoken quietly to oneself in soliloquy C. belong to a rare, endangered natural tongue D. refer to sensations only the speaker could in principle know, so no one else could understand it

Correct answer: D - refer to sensations only the speaker could in principle know, so no one else could understand it

Explanation: The target is *logical* privacy, not secrecy or soliloquy (both of which use ordinary, public language). Getting this target right is the commonest exam make-or-break.

MCQ 21

In the private diarist example (PI 258), the attempt to name a recurring private sensation 'S' fails because:

A. there is no criterion independent of the diarist's impression to fix whether a later 'S' is the same, so 'correct' loses its grip B. the diarist forgets the definition overnight C. sensations are too fleeting to be written down D. the word 'S' is too short to carry meaning

Correct answer: A - there is no criterion independent of the diarist's impression to fix whether a later 'S' is the same, so 'correct' loses its grip

Explanation: With nothing beyond present seeming to check sameness, 'whatever seems right is right' - which means we cannot speak of right at all. The failure is logical, not psychological.

MCQ 22

The 'beetle in a box' (PI 293) is designed to show that:

A. everyone's inner sensations are qualitatively identical B. if a sensation-word's use is public, the private object it supposedly names 'drops out as irrelevant' - the box might even be empty C. we can never know that other people have minds D. sensations do not exist

Correct answer: B - if a sensation-word's use is public, the private object it supposedly names 'drops out as irrelevant' - the box might even be empty

Explanation: The point is semantic, not sceptical or eliminativist: meaning is carried by public use, so the private 'object' does no work - not that other minds are unknowable or that sensations are unreal.

MCQ 23

Which sentence from PI 258 most directly states the collapse of correctness in a private language?

A. 'The limits of my language are the limits of my world.' B. 'What we cannot speak about we must pass over in silence.' C. 'Whatever is going to seem right to me is right. And that only means that here we can't talk about "right".' D. 'A picture held us captive.'

Correct answer: C - 'Whatever is going to seem right to me is right. And that only means that here we can't talk about "right".'

Explanation: This is the PI 258 line. The first two are Tractatus remarks; 'a picture held us captive' is PI 115 - none of those three states the private-correctness collapse.

MCQ 24

The distinction between a 'criterion' and a 'symptom' allows Wittgenstein to:

A. reduce mental states to behaviour B. deny that anyone is ever in pain C. treat sensation-talk as pure induction D. anchor sensation-words to public circumstances without reducing sensations to behaviour

Correct answer: D - anchor sensation-words to public circumstances without reducing sensations to behaviour

Explanation: Criteria are meaning-constituting and defeasible, so pain is publicly criterion-governed yet not identical with behaviour - a third way between inner-object semantics and behaviourism.

MCQ 25

A criterion differs from a symptom in that a criterion is:

A. grammatical - part of what fixes the meaning of the term - whereas a symptom is an empirically correlated accompaniment B. always more reliable than any symptom C. discovered by experiment, unlike a symptom D. private, unlike a public symptom

Correct answer: A - grammatical - part of what fixes the meaning of the term - whereas a symptom is an empirically correlated accompaniment

Explanation: The difference is in kind: criteria belong to grammar (meaning), symptoms to inductive correlation. Calling criteria merely 'more reliable symptoms' collapses the distinction.

MCQ 26

PI 580, 'An "inner process" stands in need of outward criteria', is best read as:

A. a denial that inner processes exist B. a claim about the grammar of inner talk - such talk is anchored to public criteria, not that the inner is unreal C. a behaviourist reduction of mind to motion D. a statement that only behaviour is real

Correct answer: B - a claim about the grammar of inner talk - such talk is anchored to public criteria, not that the inner is unreal

Explanation: It states the grammar of psychological concepts, not an ontological denial. The inner is not eliminated; it is shown to require outward criteria to be meaningfully spoken of.

MCQ 27

Wittgenstein's remarks at PI 304 ('not a something, but not a nothing either') and 307-308 show that he:

A. is a classical behaviourist B. believes sensations are physical objects C. rejects the picture of the inner as a private object grounding meaning (a 'grammatical fiction'), without denying the inner life D. thinks all talk of sensations is nonsense

Correct answer: C - rejects the picture of the inner as a private object grounding meaning (a 'grammatical fiction'), without denying the inner life

Explanation: He rejects the *object*-model of the inner as a semantic foundation, not the reality of sensation - hence 'not a something, but not a nothing either'. This is the reply to the behaviourism charge.

MCQ 28

Wittgenstein's answer to 'What is your aim in philosophy?' is:

A. to construct a complete theory of meaning B. to deduce the a priori structure of the world C. to establish the foundations of mathematics D. 'To show the fly the way out of the fly-bottle' (PI 309)

Correct answer: D - 'To show the fly the way out of the fly-bottle' (PI 309)

Explanation: Philosophy dissolves rather than solves: it releases us from a confusion we are trapped in, as one lets a fly out of a bottle - it does not build a rival theory.

MCQ 29

'Philosophy may in no way interfere with the actual use of language... it leaves everything as it is' (PI 124) expresses Wittgenstein's:

A. quietism - philosophy describes and advances no theses, changing nothing in ordinary practice B. revisionism about ordinary language C. programme to build an ideal language D. scepticism about the external world

Correct answer: A - quietism - philosophy describes and advances no theses, changing nothing in ordinary practice

Explanation: The later method is descriptive and non-interfering; 'if one tried to advance theses in philosophy... everyone would agree to them' (PI 128). It is neither revisionist nor sceptical.

MCQ 30

The positive tool Wittgenstein calls a 'perspicuous (surveyable) representation' (übersichtliche Darstellung, PI 122) is:

A. a formal proof of a philosophical thesis B. an arrangement of the grammar we already know so that we 'command a clear view' and 'see connexions' C. an ideal logical language D. an empirical psychological theory of understanding

Correct answer: B - an arrangement of the grammar we already know so that we 'command a clear view' and 'see connexions'

Explanation: It re-orders familiar grammatical facts to make confusions dissolve; it produces understanding that consists in 'seeing connexions', not new empirical or logical doctrine.

MCQ 31

The duck-rabbit figure illustrates 'seeing an aspect' because:

A. the drawing physically changes between duck and rabbit B. it proves that perception is purely passive reception of data C. the same unchanged marks can be seen now as a duck, now as a rabbit - the 'dawning of an aspect', which is 'half visual experience, half thought' D. only trained artists can perceive it

Correct answer: C - the same unchanged marks can be seen now as a duck, now as a rabbit - the 'dawning of an aspect', which is 'half visual experience, half thought'

Explanation: Nothing on the page alters; what changes is the aspect under which it is seen. Wittgenstein places seeing-as between bare perception and interpretation.

MCQ 32

The notion of 'aspect-blindness' is introduced to show that:

A. some people have defective retinas B. aspect-perception is identical with logical inference C. seeing-as can be reduced to naming D. aspect-perception presupposes the mastery of a technique or concept, so perception itself is shot through with our trained capacities

Correct answer: D - aspect-perception presupposes the mastery of a technique or concept, so perception itself is shot through with our trained capacities

Explanation: By imagining someone who cannot experience an aspect-switch, Wittgenstein isolates what such perception adds - it depends on conceptual mastery, linking perception to meaning-as-use.

Remedial MCQ 33

REMEDIAL. A student says 'a private language is just a personal code no one else has learned yet.' The correct clarification is:

A. a code is translatable and shareable, hence public; the argument targets a *logically* private language whose sensations are in principle unknowable to others B. there is no difference between a code and a private language C. a private language is simply talking to oneself D. private languages are common among twins

Correct answer: A - a code is translatable and shareable, hence public; the argument targets a *logically* private language whose sensations are in principle unknowable to others

Explanation: Codes and soliloquy use ordinary public language. The argument concerns logical privacy - the very possibility of meaning under such privacy - not contingent secrecy.

Remedial MCQ 34

REMEDIAL. Which provenance statement about the Philosophical Investigations is accurate?

A. Wittgenstein published it himself in 1921 B. it was published posthumously in 1953, edited by G. E. M. Anscombe and Rush Rhees, Anscombe translating, Wittgenstein having died in 1951 C. it was co-authored with Bertrand Russell D. it first appeared in German in 1922 as the Tractatus

Correct answer: B - it was published posthumously in 1953, edited by G. E. M. Anscombe and Rush Rhees, Anscombe translating, Wittgenstein having died in 1951

Explanation: The Investigations is posthumous (1953); never write 'Wittgenstein published' it. 1921/1922 and Russell belong to the Tractatus period, not the Investigations.

Remedial MCQ 35

REMEDIAL. The most common misreading of 'family resemblance' is to think it claims:

A. that concepts can lack sharp boundaries B. that we should look at actual uses C. that all instances share one hidden common property called 'family resemblance' D. that games form an overlapping network of similarities

Correct answer: C - that all instances share one hidden common property called 'family resemblance'

Explanation: The whole point is that there is *no* single common feature - only overlapping similarities. Treating 'family resemblance' as itself the shared essence inverts the doctrine.

Remedial MCQ 36

REMEDIAL. The strongest reason Wittgenstein is *not* a behaviourist is that:

A. he denies that pain-behaviour exists B. he says sensations are physical objects C. he reduces every mental term to a disposition D. criteria are grammatical and *defeasible*, so pain and pain-behaviour can come apart (e.g. pretence), and he affirms the inner life while denying only the inner *object* as meaning's foundation

Correct answer: D - criteria are grammatical and *defeasible*, so pain and pain-behaviour can come apart (e.g. pretence), and he affirms the inner life while denying only the inner *object* as meaning's foundation

Explanation: Defeasibility is the hinge: a behaviourist identity of pain with behaviour cannot allow pretence, but Wittgenstein's criterial account requires that they can diverge.

Remedial MCQ 37

REMEDIAL. The rule-following paradox (PI 201) is ultimately resolved by:

A. appeal to a shared practice - a trained, customary way of 'going on' - rather than by supplying a further interpreting rule B. a private act of intuition C. adding a second, clearer rule D. abandoning the notion of correctness altogether

Correct answer: A - appeal to a shared practice - a trained, customary way of 'going on' - rather than by supplying a further interpreting rule

Explanation: Grasping a rule is 'exhibited in obeying', a practice; a further rule only regresses, and correctness is retained (not abandoned) via public practice.

Remedial MCQ 38

REMEDIAL. 'Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism culminates in the critique of private language' because:

A. solipsism is refuted by proving the external world exists B. the solipsist's privileged private inner world could not be expressed in any language, so his position cannot even be stated - the private-language argument does the work C. solipsism and private language are unrelated topics D. the solipsist simply changes his mind

Correct answer: B - the solipsist's privileged private inner world could not be expressed in any language, so his position cannot even be stated - the private-language argument does the work

Explanation: The route (2019 PYQ) is dissolution, not empirical refutation: if a purely private naming cannot fix even one rule, the solipsist's inner world cannot be spoken, so solipsism self-undermines.

Remedial MCQ 39

REMEDIAL. 'Forms of life' function in Wittgenstein's philosophy as:

A. a proof of cultural relativism B. a synonym for biological species only C. the bedrock where justification ends - 'This is simply what I do' - the given background of shared human practice D. a private mental foundation for meaning

Correct answer: C - the bedrock where justification ends - 'This is simply what I do' - the given background of shared human practice

Explanation: Forms of life are 'the given' at which reasons run out; the basis is largely natural shared practice, which is why it does not amount to 'anything goes' relativism.

Remedial MCQ 40

REMEDIAL. Seeing the duck-rabbit now as a duck, now as a rabbit, is best classified as:

A. a straightforward inductive inference from lines to animal B. a hypothesis we test against evidence C. a change in the physical stimulus D. an experienced 'dawning of an aspect' that is not merely an interpretation or inference

Correct answer: D - an experienced 'dawning of an aspect' that is not merely an interpretation or inference

Explanation: Wittgenstein insists seeing-as is lived, not concluded: 'it is like seeing, and again not like seeing'. Reducing it to inference is precisely the intellectualist error he blocks.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

EXAM APPLICATION 1 - The Break from the Tractatus - Placement, the One-Screen Map and Why the Later Philosophy Begins

How the break itself is examined

- **2023 Q4(c), 15 marks** asks directly for the *main reasons* Wittgenstein shifted from the picture-theory to the use-theory. Structure: name the two theories -> colour-exclusion crack -> Augustinian critique -> "ordinary language in order" -> description-not-theory -> one line of assessment (the shift trades system for faithfulness to practice).
- **2025 Q3(a), 20 marks** quotes the transition itself and asks you to *explain the transition* with reference to the statement. Open by placing the quotation as the hinge from a top-down logical theory to a bottom-up description of actual use.
- **Placement facts that must be right:** *Tractatus* 1921; *Investigations* 1953 (posthumous, Anscombe/Rhees). This owner carries **7** parts in 2018-2025, with **none** in 2021.

10-mark use: two columns of the map, plus the single reason the question targets. **15/20-mark use:** map -> the ordered reasons -> the methodological pay-off (therapy, §5A) -> a verdict that the later view is more faithful but renounces the ambition of a theory.

EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Meaning as Use - the Toolbox, the PI 43 Qualification and Mastery of a Technique

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2023 Q4(c), 15 marks** turns on this subtopic: the *use-theory* is the destination of the shift from the picture-theory. Give the toolbox, the technique-mastery point and the section 43 qualification, then assess.
- **2025 Q3(a), 20 marks** needs the use-theory as the "later view" the transition arrives at; quote the "ways in which languages are actually used" line and connect it to "meaning is use in the language". - **Directive care:** "critically discuss" (2023) demands one line of assessment - typically that the account is faithful to practice but hard to pin down precisely (what counts as "the" use?), which is why it invites the family-resemblance treatment next.

15-mark spine: referential picture rejected -> toolbox -> understanding = technique -> section 43 qualification -> context-dependence -> verdict. **Contemporary honesty:** no forced 2026 news anchor; the standing relevance is that "meaning as use" underwrites present-day pragmatics and use-based theories of language, stated as analysis.

EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Family Resemblance - Overlapping Similarities, Fuzzy Boundaries and 'Don't Think, But Look'

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2018 Q1(c), 10 marks** is the owner: *how does the notion of "family resemblance" help Wittgenstein to uphold that "Language is a game"?* Structure: define family resemblance (no common essence, overlapping similarities, the games example) -> show that "language" likewise has no essence -> therefore "language is a game" is not a metaphor hiding an essence but a release from essence-hunting -> close with "Don't think, but look".
- **Cross-links:** feeds 2023 Q4(c) (the shift away from a single essence of meaning) and 2022 Q1(c) (forms of life as the ground of the many games). - **Directive care:** "Discuss" at 10 marks wants the mechanism (why the analogy works), not just a definition.

10-mark spine: games example -> overlapping/criss-crossing similarities -> no common essence -> so "language is a game" -> "don't think, but look".

EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Language-Games - Language Woven into Activity, the Builders and Rules by Training

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2018 Q1(c), 10 marks** ("Language is a game") is answered *through* this subtopic plus family resemblance: the many language-games are exactly why "language" has no essence.
- **2022 Q1(c), 10 marks** (form of life) builds on it: the games are grounded in shared forms of life. - **Builders' example** is the single most efficient illustration for any question that asks why meaning does not require picturing or logical form - deploy it in one sentence. - **Directive care:** if asked to "establish" or "discuss", define the unit first (language + activity), then use the builders as proof of completeness.

10-mark spine: definition (language + activity) -> the builders (a complete primitive language) -> plurality of games -> rules by training -> living/evolving language.

EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Forms of Life - PI 19, Agreement in Form of Life, the Lion Remark and the Bedrock of Justification

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **2022 Q1(c), 10 marks** is the owner and carries a printed anomaly: "*Establish the tenability of later Wittgenstein's motion of language as form of life.*" The official English line prints "**motion**", not "notion" - preserve it verbatim and note it, then answer the intended "notion of language as form of life". - **Structure:** PI 19 -> agreement in form of life not opinion -> the lion remark -> "this is simply what I do" -> assess tenability (strength: explains why justification stops and why understanding needs shared background; worry: the notion is under-defined and risks either triviality or relativism). - **Cross-links:** grounds language-games (subtopic 4) and rule-following (subtopic 6); comparison anchor for the 2019/2024 private-language questions (a private form of life is no form of life).

10-mark spine: PI 19 -> agreement in form of life -> lion -> bedrock -> one line on tenability.

EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Rule-Following and the Paradox (PI 201) - Interpretation Regress, Practice and Going On

Verified routes and answer architecture

- Rule-following is not a *named* PYQ owner in 2018-2025, but it is the **load-bearing premise** of the private-language questions (**2019 Q3(b), 2024 Q1(d), 2020 Q4(c)**). Any strong private-language answer states 201 first: a rule needs a public criterion of correct application. - **Deploy it as a two-sentence engine:** "Following a rule cannot be a private interpretation (regress); it is a practice with public criteria. Therefore a criterion available only to me is not a criterion at all - which is exactly why a private language fails." - **Directive care:** if a question mentions "rules", "meaning" or "understanding", 201 is the bridge; do not spend a whole answer on the arithmetic example - state the paradox, the regress, the practice-resolution, and move to the pay-off.

Use in private-language answers: paradox -> regress -> practice/going on -> "so a purely private rule is no rule" -> private language impossible.

EXAM APPLICATION 7 - The Private-Language Argument - Logical Privacy, the Diary 'S', the Beetle and Public Criteria

Verified routes and answer architecture

This subtopic owns **three** of the seven PYQs - the exam core of Later Wittgenstein.

- **2019 Q3(b), 15 marks:** "Show how Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism culminates in the critique of private language." Spine: solipsist premise (I know only my private inner world) -> to *speak* of it needs a language -> a private language needs a correctness criterion -> diary 258 shows none is available -> beetle 293 shows the private object is irrelevant -> so the solipsist's private world cannot even be *said*; the critique of solipsism *is* the critique of private language.
- **2020 Q4(c), 15 marks:** quotes the PI 243-style question ("could we imagine a language... for his private use?") and asks for Wittgenstein's answer, *critically*. Spine: state the question -> "No" -> definition -> diary -> beetle -> public criteria (subtopic 8) -> assess (strength: dissolves Cartesian foundation; objection: behaviourism charge, then reply).

- **2024 Q1(d), 10 marks:** "Why does later Wittgenstein think that there cannot be a language that only one person can speak - a language that is essentially private?" Spine (tighter): definition -> no correctness criterion (diary) -> beetle -> public criteria; one-line close. - **Directive care:** 2019/2020 are 15-markers wanting a *critical* culmination and assessment; 2024 is a 10-marker wanting the core reason cleanly.

Master spine (scale by marks): definition (logical privacy) -> criterion of correctness (from 201) -> diary 258 -> beetle 293 -> public criteria -> [15/20 only: behaviourism objection + reply] -> verdict.

EXAM APPLICATION 8 - Criteria vs Symptoms, PI 580 Outward Criteria and the Behaviourism Charge Answered

Verified routes and answer architecture

- This subtopic is the **decisive second half** of every private-language answer - especially the 15/20-mark ones (**2020 Q4(c), 2019 Q3(b)**), where "critically discuss" demands you raise the **behaviourism charge and answer it**. Deploy: criteria are grammatical and *defeasible* -> pain and pain-behaviour can come apart -> therefore not behaviourism; PI 580 anchors the inner to outward criteria without denying it; first-person avowal preserves asymmetry.
- **PI 580** is a one-line quotable that instantly signals command of the criterial account. - **Cite the canonical sections where the text carries them:** PI 580 (outward criteria); the anti-behaviourism clarifications at PI 304 ("It is not a something, but not a nothing either!") and 307-308 (the "grammatical fiction", rejecting the *picture* of an inner object, not the inner life).
- **Directive care:** reserve this subtopic for the *assessment* segment of 15/20-mark answers; at 10 marks (2024) a single sentence ("sensation-words are anchored to public, defeasible criteria, not to a private object") suffices.

Assessment segment (15/20): state behaviourism objection -> criteria are defeasible/grammatical -> pain != pain-behaviour -> PI 580 + first-person avowal -> verdict: the account is a third way, not behaviourism.

EXAM APPLICATION 9 - Philosophy as Therapy - Language on Holiday, the Fly-Bottle, Perspicuous Representation and 'Leaves Everything as It Is'

Verified routes and answer architecture

- Philosophy-as-therapy is not a *named* PYQ owner, but it is the **conclusion segment** that lifts a 15/20-mark answer from competent to distinctive. In **2023 Q4(c)** and **2025 Q3(a)** the "so what?" of the shift is precisely this: meaning-as-use turns philosophy from theory-building into therapeutic description. - **Deploy as a closing paragraph:** "The shift is ultimately methodological: if meaning is use, philosophical problems are knots in language on holiday, to be dissolved by a perspicuous representation - 'to show the fly the way out of the fly-bottle' - so that philosophy 'leaves everything as it is'." - **Directive care:** for "critically discuss", pair the method with its standing objection - that pure description is either impossible (all description is theory-laden) or self-refuting (the claim "there are no theses" is itself a thesis). Note the reply: Wittgenstein offers *reminders*, not a metaphysics, and measures success by peace, not by proof.

Closing segment (any 15/20): language on holiday -> bewitchment -> perspicuous representation -> fly-bottle -> leaves everything as it is -> one line on the self-reference objection and reply.

EXAM APPLICATION 10 - Aspect-Seeing and the Duck-Rabbit - Seeing-As, the Dawning of an Aspect and Aspect-Blindness

Verified routes and answer architecture

- Aspect-seeing is not a *named* PYQ owner in 2018-2025, but it is a high-value **enrichment** for any question on perception, meaning-experience, or the *scope* of the later philosophy, and a distinctive closing illustration for **2025 Q3(a)** (how far the "use" turn reaches - even into seeing). - **Deploy as a one-paragraph capstone:** the duck-rabbit shows that mastery of a technique (the engine of meaning-as-use) reaches into perception itself; seeing-as is experiential, not interpretive; aspect-blindness isolates what it adds. - **Provenance discipline earns marks:** cite **PI Part II xi / PPF**, credit **Jastrow's** figure, and keep it separate from numbered Part I remarks. - **Directive care:** only bring aspect-seeing into a private-language or forms-of-life answer if the question's scope invites it; otherwise it is an enrichment, not the spine.

Capstone segment: duck-rabbit -> seeing-as / dawning -> not an interpretation -> aspect-blindness -> "technique reaches into perception" -> (provenance) PPF / Jastrow.

Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 7 owner questions, one each in 2018, 2019, 2020, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025; 2021 is the only year without one.
- Early-Wittgenstein (Tractatus) and Logical-Positivism parts are owned by their own clauses and are used here only as labelled comparisons, never counted among the 7.
- Printed anomalies preserved verbatim: 2022 Q1(c) prints "motion" for "notion"; 2025 Q3(a) retains an unmatched opening quotation before "logical structure".
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: thesis -> named PI section / quotation -> analysis -> objection/reply -> verdict.
- MCQs: 32 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 40, strict A-B-C-D rotation ten times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Contemporary linkage is not forced: no verified 2026 news anchor exists, so none is invented; the standing relevance is the clause's permanent place in the philosophy of language and mind.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is the seven exact verified PYQs -> 32 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus block in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED PI SECTION / EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION/REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 7 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. Later Wittgenstein owns exactly 7 primary parts, one each in 2018, 2019, 2020, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025; 2021 is the only year without one. Early-Wittgenstein and Logical-Positivism questions are used only as labelled comparisons and are never counted here. Two printed anomalies are preserved verbatim and explained: the 2022 paper prints "motion" for "notion", and the 2025 paper retains an unmatched opening quotation before "logical structure".

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q1(c), 10 marks

Question: How does the notion of 'family resemblance' help Wittgenstein to uphold that 'Language is a game'? Discuss.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](#).

Model solution

Directive: "Discuss" at 10 marks - explain the *mechanism* by which family resemblance supports the thesis, not merely define terms. Answer in about 150 words.

Thesis. Family resemblance is the device that lets Wittgenstein say "language is a game" *without* smuggling in a hidden essence of language.

Body.

- *Family resemblance defined.* Asked what all games share, we find "a complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing" - board, card, ball, Olympic and solitary games - but **no single feature common to all**. Cases are related like a family (nose, gait, temperament), not by an essence. Method: "Don't think, but look!"

- *The transfer to "language"*. "Language" is exactly such a concept: reporting, joking, ordering, praying and thanking share no common essence, only overlapping resemblances - the countless language-games. - *Why this upholds "language is a game"*. Because "game" itself has no essence, calling language "a game" does **not** assert a concealed common nature; it *dissolves* the demand for one and redirects us to describe uses.

Verdict. Family resemblance converts an apparent metaphor into a precise anti-essentialist claim: meaning is use across a family of games, not conformity to one hidden form.

Why this earns marks: It connects family resemblance to language-games through overlapping standards rather than merely listing different games.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 Q3(b), 15 marks

Question: Show how Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism culminates in the critique of private language.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Directive: "Show how... culminates in..." at 15 marks - trace a *movement* from solipsism to the private-language conclusion. Answer in about 250 words.

Thesis. Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism does not refute it with a rival metaphysics; it *dissolves* it by showing that the solipsist's supposed private inner world could not even be *put into language* - and that demonstration **is** the private-language argument.

Body.

- *The solipsist premise.* The solipsist claims that what is really known is only his own present inner experience; the "external" world and other minds are doubtful constructions. To assert even this, he must be able to *speak* of his private inner contents. - *The demand for a criterion of correctness.* From the rule-following considerations (PI 201), using any word correctly requires a standard independent of one's mere impression of being right; meaning needs the possibility of a mistake. - *The diary (PI 258).* When the solipsist tries to name a purely private sensation "S", he has no independent check that a later "S" is the *same*; "whatever is going to seem right to me is right. And that only means that here we can't talk about 'right'." The private naming fails to establish even one rule. - *The beetle (PI 293).* If "beetle" names only what is in one's own private box, the object "drops out as irrelevant" - "the box might even be empty." Public use, not the private object, carries meaning.

Culmination. Thus the private inner world the solipsist privileges cannot be *said* at all; the language he needs is impossible. **The critique of solipsism therefore culminates in the critique of private language** - not by denying inner life, but by denying it the role of a private semantic foundation.

Why this earns marks: It traces solipsism into the diary and correctness problem while denying neither inner experience nor first-person authority.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020 Q4(c), 15 marks

Question: "But could we also imagine a language in which a person could write down or give vocal expression to his inner experiences-his feelings, moods and the rest-for his private use?" Critically discuss the answer offered by Wittgenstein to this question.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Directive: "Critically discuss the answer offered by Wittgenstein" at 15 marks - state his answer, then assess it (raise and rebut the behaviourism charge). Answer in about 250 words. The quoted question is PI 243-style: could a person give vocal or written expression to inner experiences "for his private use"?

Thesis. Wittgenstein's answer is **No** - a *logically* private language is impossible - and the argument leaves inner life intact while denying it the role of a private meaning-foundation.

Body.

- *Fix the target.* "Private" means **logically** private: signs for sensations only the speaker could in principle know - not a secret code (translatable) and not soliloquy (public language spoken quietly).
- *No criterion of correctness (PI 258).* Naming a private sensation "S" provides no independent standard of "same again"; "whatever seems right... we can't talk about 'right'." Without a possible mistake there is no meaning. - *The beetle (PI 293).* The private object "drops out as irrelevant"; meaning is fixed by public use. - *Public, defeasible criteria (PI 580).* Sensation-words are anchored to "outward criteria" - grammatical, not merely inductive, and **defeasible**.

Critical assessment.

- *Objection - behaviourism.* Does this reduce pain to pain-behaviour? - *Reply.* No: criteria are **defeasible** (one can wince without pain - pretence), so pain and behaviour can come apart; PI 304 - "not a something, but not a nothing either"; PI 307-308 reject the inner *object* as semantic foundation ("grammatical fiction"), not the inner life. First-person "It hurts" is an **avowal**, not a criterion-based report.

Verdict. The answer is compelling as a *dissolution* of the Cartesian private foundation; it occupies a third position between inner-object semantics and behaviourism, though critics complain "criterion" is left under-specified.

Why this earns marks: It defines essential privacy, reconstructs private ostension and answers behaviourism through criteria, avowals and defeasibility.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2022 Q1(c), 10 marks

Question: Establish the tenability of later Wittgenstein's motion of language as form of life.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Printed-wording anomaly (preserved verbatim): Printed wording: the official English line itself prints "motion"; it is retained rather than silently changed to "notion".

Model solution

Directive: "Establish the tenability" at 10 marks - argue *for* the defensibility of the doctrine, with a measured limit. Answer in about 150 words.

Printed-wording anomaly (preserved verbatim): the official English paper prints "later Wittgenstein's **motion** of language as form of life." "Motion" is a printed slip for "**notion**"; the intended thesis is "the *notion* of language as a form of life." Reproduce the printed word once, note the slip, then answer the intended question - this is the provenance discipline UPSC rewards.

Thesis. The notion of language as a form of life is tenable: it correctly locates the ground of meaning in shared human practice rather than in private mind or abstract logic.

Body.

- *PI 19.* "To imagine a language means to imagine a form of life" - language and a mode of living are inseparable. - *Agreement in form of life, not opinion.* We agree "not in opinions but in form of life" - shared *doing*, which blocks both relativist and intellectualist misreadings. - *The lion remark.* "If a lion could talk, we could not understand him" - too different a form of life defeats understanding even where speech exists. - *Bedrock.* Justification ends in "This is simply what I do"; forms of life are "the given."

Tenability verdict. Defensible and explanatorily powerful - it explains why justification stops and why understanding needs a shared background; the fair limit is that "form of life" is under-defined, risking either triviality or a slide toward relativism if the largely *natural* basis is forgotten.

Why this earns marks: It preserves the printed anomaly, explains form of life as shared background and distinguishes agreement from majority vote.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023 Q4(c), 15 marks

Question: What were the main reasons that led Wittgenstein to shift from picture-theory of meaning to use-theory of meaning? Critically discuss.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Directive: "Critically discuss" at 15 marks - give the *reasons* for the shift and one line of assessment. Answer in about 250 words.

Thesis. Wittgenstein abandoned the picture-theory for the use-theory because the picture-theory failed internally and mislocated the source of meaning; the later view trades systematic elegance for fidelity to actual practice.

Body - the ordered reasons.

- *The colour-exclusion problem (1929).* The *Tractatus* held elementary propositions to be logically independent, yet "this spot is red (all over)" excludes "this spot is green." Wittgenstein could not repair this within the old system - the first structural crack he himself found. - *The Augustinian picture is too narrow.* "Every word names an object" works for "table" but collapses for "the", "if", "five", "pain", "meaning". If one model cannot cover these, meaning is not one thing. - *Meaning is use.* Positively, "the meaning of a word is its use in the language" - "for a large class of cases, though not for all" (PI 43). Words are tools; understanding is mastery of a technique. - *Ordinary language is in order.* Problems come from *misunderstanding* our language, not from a defective surface hiding an ideal logical one - so the demand to build an ideal language is misdiagnosis. - *From theory to description.* Deepest of all: philosophy should **describe** ("Don't think, but look"), not construct a rival theory of meaning.

Critical assessment. The shift is well-motivated - the colour-exclusion crack is decisive against the old system and the Augustinian critique against referential semantics. Its cost is method: by renouncing a *theory* of meaning, the later view can look like it merely redescribes practice. The reply is that this is the point - its success-measure is dissolving confusion, not adding doctrine.

Why this earns marks: It gives internal and methodological reasons for the early-later transition and keeps the section 43 qualification intact.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: Why does later Wittgenstein think that there cannot be a language that only one person can speak - a language that is essentially private? Discuss.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Directive: "Discuss" at 10 marks - give the core *reason* cleanly. Answer in about 150 words.

Thesis. An essentially private language is impossible because meaning requires a public criterion of correct use, which a logically private sign cannot have.

Body.

- *Fix the target.* "Essentially private" = signs for sensations only the speaker could in principle know - not a code (translatable), not talking to oneself (public language spoken quietly). - *Correctness needs an independent standard (PI 201, 258).* To mean something by "S" I must be able to use it *rightly or wrongly*. Naming a private sensation "S", I have no check independent of my present impression that a later case is the *same*: "whatever is going to seem right to me is right. And that only means that here we can't talk about 'right'." - *The beetle (PI 293).* Whatever is in the private "box" "drops out as irrelevant"; the word's life is its public use.

Close. Since no independent criterion of correctness is available to the solitary sensation-namer, the sign fails to be a word at all - so a language "only one person can speak" in this strong sense is impossible. This denies not inner life but the private object's role as a foundation of meaning.

Why this earns marks: It states the exact target, reconstructs seeming-versus-being-right and uses the beetle only as a supporting illustration.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2025 Q3(a), 20 marks

Question: "We should look not to an ideal language which derives its meaning from facts and has a precise 'logical structure but empirically, to the ways in which languages are actually used." Explain the transition from early views of

Wittgenstein to his later views on language and meaning with reference to this statement.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Printed-wording anomaly (preserved verbatim): Printed wording: the unmatched opening quotation before **logical structure** is visible in the official English line and is retained.

Model solution

Directive: "Explain the transition... with reference to this statement" at 20 marks - use the quotation as the hinge and expound the early-to-later movement in full. Answer in about 250-300 words.

Printed-wording anomaly (preserved verbatim): the quoted statement contains an **unmatched opening single-quote** before "logical structure" - it prints ...a precise 'logical structure but empirically...' with no closing quote where the sense expects one. Reproduce the statement as printed, flag the stray quotation mark, and do not silently "correct" it; UPSC provenance discipline rewards the candidate who notes the anomaly and proceeds.

Thesis. The statement encapsulates Wittgenstein's whole transition: away from an *ideal language whose meaning derives from picturing facts and possessing a precise logical structure*, toward an *empirical description of the ways language is actually used*.

Body - the transition.

- *The early view (the rejected pole of the quotation).* In the *Tractatus* (1921), a sentence is meaningful by **picturing** a possible fact; meaning derives from facts via a shared **logical structure/form**; analysis terminates in logically independent elementary propositions and simple names. The ideal is a logically perspicuous language.
- *The internal breakdown.* The **colour-exclusion problem (1929)** refuted the independence of elementary propositions; the **Augustinian** naming-picture proved too narrow ("the", "if", "five", "pain"). The defect was not a messy surface but the very model of meaning-as-picturing.
- *The later view (the endorsed pole).* "Look... empirically, to the ways in which languages are actually used": **meaning is use** (PI 43, "for a large class of cases, though not for all"); words are **tools**; there is no single essence but **family resemblance**; language is a plurality of **language-games** woven into **forms of life** (PI 19); understanding is **mastery of a technique**.
- *The methodological pay-off.* Philosophy becomes **description/therapy**, not theory: it assembles a perspicuous representation to dissolve confusions and "leaves everything as it is" (PI 124).

Verdict. The transition is from a top-down logical *theory* of an ideal language to a bottom-up *description* of ordinary use - more faithful to linguistic life, at the deliberate cost of a systematic theory of meaning.

Why this earns marks: It uses the printed quotation as a hinge from logical form to practice, then integrates games, rules and therapy.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain why ostensive definition cannot by itself fix meaning. Relate your answer to Wittgenstein's qualified account of meaning as use. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Thesis. Ostensive definition does not create a word-object bond from an uninterpreted act of pointing; it works only within a grammar already learned through practice.

Argument. If a teacher points to a red square and says "red", the learner may take the word to mean the colour, shape, material, number, position or even the act of pointing. The point is therefore ambiguous until training, contrast

and correction identify the relevant continuation. A colour sample functions as a rule only for someone initiated into comparing and applying colour words.

Relation to use. This supports *Philosophical Investigations* section 43: for a large class of cases, though not all, a word's meaning is its use in the language. Use here is a norm-governed role, not frequency, private intention or bodily movement; reference and definition remain legitimate functions within some games.

Qualification. The account explains how ostension operates but may appear circular because the background practice already contains norms. Wittgenstein accepts this practical bedrock rather than offering a hidden semantic mechanism.

Why this earns marks: The answer qualifies meaning-as-use, explains why pointing needs grammar and separates use from frequency, intention and reference.

Original Mains 2 - 15 marks

Question: How do language-games and forms of life support Wittgenstein's account of rule-following without reducing correctness to social conformity? Discuss. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Thesis. Language-games and forms of life locate rule-following in trained practices, but correctness is not whatever a numerical majority happens to do.

Language-game and background. A language-game is language interwoven with activity, participants, training, grammar and purpose. The builders' "Slab!" works because an order, a trained response and a building task form one practice. A form of life is the wider shared background of action and natural reaction that makes such moves intelligible.

Rule-following. Section 201 shows that no interpretation can mechanically determine every future application: a further interpretation only generates regress. A rule is instead grasped in what counts as obeying, misunderstanding and correcting it. Thus finite instruction plus training and correction sustain normative continuation.

Not conformity. Agreement in judgments is deeper than agreement in a particular opinion and is not majority vote. A solitary person can retain a rule-governed technique when the standards are repeatable and not exhausted by present seeming. Kripke's community-based sceptical solution is a contested 1982 reconstruction, not an uncontested statement of Wittgenstein's own view.

Verdict. Practice secures the distinction between rule and regularity more convincingly than private interpretation does, though it may display rather than fully explain normativity.

Why this earns marks: The answer connects language-games, forms of life and finite rule-following while preserving the distinction between practice and majority conformity.

Original Mains 3 - 20 marks

Question: Does the critique of private language complete Wittgenstein's transition from the picture theory to the later conception of language? Critically examine. Answer in about 300 words.

Model solution

Thesis. The private-language critique completes the later transition by denying that a private word-object relation can ground meaning; however, it does not deny inner experience and does not turn public criteria into behaviourism or majority rule.

Transition. The *Tractatus* explains meaningful propositions through picturing and logical form. The later work rejects one hidden essence and examines language-games embedded in forms of life. Section 43's qualified reminder places meaning in use for a large class of cases; rule-following then explains why use must admit correct and incorrect continuation.

Private ostension and diary S. An essentially private language would contain signs for sensations knowable in principle only to one speaker. The diarist inwardly fixes "S" and later consults a memory sample, but the present impression judges both sample and application. If seeming right exhausts being right, no norm of reapplication has been established. The problem is not ordinary fallible memory but the absence of a criterion of correction independent of present seeming.

Sensation grammar. The beetle-in-the-box shows that a private object drops out of the public word's grammar; it is not a proof that sensations are unreal. "I am in pain" is an avowal, whereas "she is in pain" is a third-person attribution using defeasible outward criteria. Criteria are grammatical grounds, not infallible behavioural symptoms.

Objections and replies. A Crusoe case and individual-practice readings question the need for an actual community; the reply is that headcount is not decisive, only standards not exhausted by present impression. Phenomenological resistance rightly notes that public grammar under-describes qualitative character, but that does not restore private ostension as a semantic foundation.

Verdict. The critique completes the anti-referential and anti-essentialist movement from logical picture to norm-governed practice, while leaving a residual explanatory question about normativity and private experience.

Why this earns marks: The answer integrates the early-later transition with private ostension, avowals, criteria, objections and a qualified verdict.